User Manual

Find your role. Read that chapter. Read the orientation first if it is your first day.

Start here

Getting started — signing in, two-factor, branches, the language switch, and the five behaviours of this system that will otherwise surprise you. Twenty minutes, once.

Then your role

IF YOU ARE	READ	YOU WILL SPEND MOST OF YOUR TIME IN
Moving shipments day to day	**Coordinator**	Dashboard, Shipments, Enquiries
Running the operation	**Operations Manager**	Dashboard, Exceptions, Rate cards
Answering enquiries and quoting	**Sales**	Enquiries, Quotations
Invoicing and chasing money	**Finance**	Finance overview, Invoices, Payments
Clearing cargo	**Customs Broker**	Customs
Running the system itself	**Administrator**	Settings

Chapters are cumulative where roles are: the operations manager's chapter assumes you have read the coordinator's, and does not repeat it.

To hand out

These two are written to be sent under your own brand. They name no software and carry no supplier logo. Replace the bracketed tokens at the top and delete the note.

Tracking your shipments	**For your customers.** The public tracking page and the portal.
Agents and partners	**Read this yourself first.** The agent portal is a scaffold in this release, and this chapter says what to tell an agent in the meantime.

Reference

Who can do what — the full permission matrix, the four deliberate separations of duty, and the answers to the questions an auditor asks. Keep this to hand before granting anyone a role.

What is not in this release

Collected in one place so nobody spends an afternoon looking:

	STATUS
Automatic carrier tracking feeds	Not in this release. Milestones are entered by your team.
Direct customs filing, Kuwait	**Not planned.** Declarations are tracked, not filed.
UAE MPCI filing	Roadmap
Saudi ZATCA e-invoicing	Roadmap
Agent portal — RFQ response, agent posting	In delivery. Route scoped, screens not built.
Email and WhatsApp notifications	In delivery
Scheduled email reports	In delivery. Every screen exports today.
Accounting-package connectors	Export today, connectors later
Self-service password reset	Needs a mail transport. Administrator resets today.
A user-invitation screen	Accounts are created from a shell.

If your supplier tells you one of these has shipped, ask to see it on your own deployment. This table is maintained against the working software rather than against a plan.

Conventions in these chapters

Screen names	Written as they appear: *Operations → Customs*
Permission keys	In `code`, e.g. `invoice.issue` — send the key to your administrator, not a description of the screen
In delivery	Scaffolded, being finished, has a release
Not planned	Will not be built, with the reason given

Nothing in this manual describes a capability the software does not have. Where a chapter would naturally describe one, it says so instead — chapter 8 is the clearest example, and it is the model for the rest.

Getting started

Read this once, on your first day. Then go to the chapter for your role.

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1. Signing in

Go to your company's Cargolane address — it is on your own domain, something like `ops.yourcompany.com`. You will see a sign-in page with your company's logo on it.

There is no sign-up form, and this is deliberate. Accounts are created by your administrator. If you do not have one, you are asking the wrong person for software — ask the person who runs your systems.

If you are an Administrator or work in Finance

You will be asked to set up **two-factor authentication** the first time you sign in. Install an authenticator app on your phone — Google Authenticator, Microsoft Authenticator, 1Password or similar — scan the code on screen, and enter the six-digit number it shows you.

From then on you need your password *and* your phone to sign in.

This is required, not optional, for those two roles. They are the two that can change who has access and can issue money documents.

If you have forgotten your password

There is no self-service reset. Ask your administrator — they can reset it, and they will give you the new one directly rather than emailing it.

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2. Finding your way around

The screen has three parts and they do not move.

Down the left, the navigation, in four groups. The groups match how a forwarding office is actually organised, rather than how the software is built:

GROUP	WHAT IS IN IT
Commercial	Dashboard · Enquiries · Quotations · Customers · Rate cards
Operations	Shipments · Exceptions · Customs · Documents
Network	Partners & agents · Ports & places · Reference data · Bulk import
Finance	Overview · Invoices · Payments

You will not see all of it. The navigation shows what your role permits. A coordinator does not see the finance group; a customs broker sees a narrow slice. This is not a limitation on you personally — it is how the separation of duties works, and every role's exact permissions are listed in `09-permissions-reference.md`.

Across the top, your branch, your name, the language switch, and — if your role includes it — a link to **Settings**.

In the middle, the screen you are on.

3. Branches

Everything in the system belongs to a branch — a shipment, a customer, an invoice, a rate card.

You see the branches you hold a role in, and only those. If you work in the Kuwait office you see Kuwait's shipments. If you hold a role in both Kuwait and Dubai, you see both, and screens that count things count both.

If you ask for something in a branch you do not have a role in, the system says **not found** — not "access denied". That is intentional: it does not confirm that the record exists.

You cannot widen your own access. Only an administrator can give you a role in another branch.

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4. Arabic and English

The language switch is at the top of every screen. It changes the entire interface, including the direction of the layout, and it changes documents and the customer-facing pages too.

Your choice is remembered. Your colleague's choice is theirs — two people can use the same system in different languages at the same time, on the same data.

Your customers get the same choice, on the tracking page and in the portal, without an account.

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5. Five things about how this system behaves

These are unusual enough to be worth knowing on day one, because each of them will otherwise surprise you.

Nothing is deleted

There is no delete button, anywhere, on anything that matters. Records are **closed**, **cancelled**, **superseded** or **deactivated** — and they stay visible.

A quotation you revise does not overwrite the old one; the old one is marked superseded and remains readable. A document you replace keeps its earlier version. This is what makes the system usable as evidence six months later, when somebody asks what you actually sent.

If something is cluttering a list, filter it — do not look for a way to remove it.

Everything is recorded

Every change is written to an audit log by the database itself: who, when, what changed, from which address. It records changes that go around the application as well as those made through it.

Nobody can edit or delete an entry — not your administrator, not your supplier's support engineers. The permission to do so does not exist on any account.

This is protection, not surveillance. When something goes wrong on a shipment, the trail shows what actually happened rather than what everyone remembers.

Money is exact, and currency-aware

Amounts are held exactly, and rounded per currency at the line. The Kuwaiti dinar carries three decimal places and the system knows it — it does not round your dinars as though they were dollars.

Every charge line stores the exchange rate that was used **and the moment it was taken**. A job quoted in dollars and invoiced in dinars still reconciles months later, because the rate is recorded rather than recalculated.

Time is measured against a working calendar

Response deadlines and clearance windows count working days on the calendar configured for that branch — Sunday to Thursday, with public holidays — not calendar days. An enquiry that arrives on Thursday afternoon is not overdue on Saturday morning.

The system tells you what is wrong first

Lists that show problems — exceptions, overdue enquiries, unpaid invoices — are ordered **oldest first**, not newest first. The logic is stated on the screens themselves: *the one nobody has looked at is the one the process missed.*

Resist the urge to sort by newest. The newest problem is the one that is already being handled.

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6. Things you can see from anywhere

Customer tracking	Opens the public tracking page — the same page your customer sees. Useful for checking what a customer is actually looking at before you ring them back.
Settings	Only if your role includes it. Users, branches, the audit log, vendor access and branding.

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7. If something looks wrong

A screen says you cannot view it. Your role does not include that permission. The message names the permission. Send the name to your administrator rather than describing the screen.

A record you expected is not there. Check the branch filter, and check whether you hold a role in the branch it belongs to.

A number looks wrong. Do not correct it by overwriting something. Open the record and look at its history — the audit trail will show what changed and when, and the answer is usually there.

Something is genuinely broken. Tell your administrator, with the shipment reference or invoice number and the time it happened. Both are what makes it findable.

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8. What is not in this release

Said here once so that nobody spends an afternoon looking for it:

Automatic carrier tracking	Milestones are entered by your team or posted by your agent. There is no live feed from the shipping line.

Direct customs filing	Declarations are tracked, not filed. You file where you file today and record the reference here.
WhatsApp and email notifications	In delivery. Templates exist; the sending channels are being finished.
Scheduled reports by email	In delivery. Every screen exports today.
Accounting-package integration	Export today; direct connectors later.
The agent portal	The route exists and is correctly scoped, but the screens are not built. Do not give an agent a login yet — see `08-agent-portal.md`.

Next: find your role.

ROLE	CHAPTER
Coordinator	`01-coordinator.md`
Operations Manager	`02-operations-manager.md`
Sales	`03-sales.md`
Finance	`04-finance.md`
Customs Broker	`05-customs-broker.md`
Administrator	`06-administrator.md`

Coordinator

You move shipments. This chapter is the whole of your day.

> Read `00-orientation.md` first if you have not. It covers signing in, branches and the five behaviours that will otherwise surprise you.

Your day, in order

Open the **Dashboard**. It opens on the things that need you, and there is a line at the top telling you how many there are. If it says nothing needs you, that is a real statement and not a placeholder — every open shipment is running to plan.

Then work in this order. It is the order the screens are built for.

1. **Needs your attention** — exceptions on live shipments, oldest first
2. **Overdue replies** — enquiries past their reply deadline
3. **Arriving this week** — what lands, and what you must have ready before it does
4. **Demurrage accruing** — containers past their free days, costing money now

Everything below is how to handle each of those.

Enquiries

Taking an enquiry

Enquiries → New enquiry. Enquiries also arrive from your website form; those appear in the queue already, marked as unassigned.

What you must capture:

FIELD	WHY IT MATTERS
Customer	Start typing — the list is your customer register. If they are new, create them (you have permission).
Mode and direction	Sea FCL, sea LCL, air, land or courier; import, export or cross-trade. This decides which rates apply and which milestones the job will get later.
Origin and destination	From the ports and places register. If a place is missing, ask your operations manager to add it — do not approximate with a nearby port.
Cargo	Weight, volume, pieces, commodity. For air and LCL these decide the chargeable weight, so an estimate here becomes a wrong price later.
Required by	Feeds the reply deadline.

Assign an owner. An enquiry with no owner has nobody's name against the clock, and it is the single most common way an enquiry is lost. You can assign it to yourself.

The clock

Every enquiry has a reply deadline, counted in **working hours on your branch's calendar**. The dashboard shows what has breached and what is due today, and the SLA watch list is ordered by whichever is closest to breaching.

You cannot stop the clock by looking at the enquiry. It stops when a quotation is sent. If an enquiry cannot be answered — the customer has gone quiet, the cargo does not exist — that is a *close*, and closing is your operations manager's or the sales team's decision, not yours. Say so rather than leaving it to breach silently.

Pricing it

Open the enquiry and start rating. The system looks for a live rate card covering that lane, mode and validity date, and prices from it — chargeable weight is calculated for the mode, and accessorials come from the catalogue.

If there is no rate card for the lane, you will be told so plainly rather than given a wrong number. That means the lane has no buying rate on file and somebody is about to price it from memory. Tell your operations manager — the rate-card screen has a whole panel for exactly this problem.

If a rate looks wrong, it is a rate-card problem and not something to correct by hand on this quotation. Fixing the card fixes every future quote; fixing this one fixes one and hides the fault.

Sending the quotation

You can send a quotation and you can revise one. A revision **supersedes** the previous version rather than replacing it — the customer's copy of what you sent before is still recoverable, which matters on the day somebody disputes it.

You cannot mark a quotation accepted or rejected, or close an enquiry as won or lost. That is the sales team's or the operations manager's call. When a customer accepts, tell whoever owns that enquiry so it is recorded properly — a job booked against an enquiry that was never closed leaves your branch's win rate wrong.

Shipments

Booking

A job normally begins from an accepted quotation, so the rates come with it and what you sold is what you costed. You can also create one directly.

Book it to move it out of draft. Booking is where the milestone template is applied — the checklist of stages for that mode and direction. Get the mode and direction right *before* booking; they decide the milestones.

Capture the references as they arrive: master bill, house bill, booking number, vessel and voyage or flight number, containers and seal numbers.

Container and bill numbers are what your customer types into the tracking page. A missing container number is a customer who cannot track their own shipment and rings you instead. This is the single highest-value data-entry habit in the whole system.

Milestones

Each shipment carries its stages with three dates: **planned**, **revised** and **actual**. All three are kept.

- **Planned** is what you expected at booking.
- **Revised** is what you expect now — update it when the carrier tells you the vessel has slipped.
- **Actual** is what happened. Fill it when it happens, not at the end of the week.

The difference between planned and actual is what your management uses to work out where time is really going. Backfilling a week of dates on a Thursday afternoon produces a shipment that looks perfect and tells nobody anything.

Updating milestones moves the shipment through its stages — departed, arrived, entered clearance, delivered. The stages you can move it to are the ones offered; if a step you expect is not there, the shipment is not in the state you think it is.

Putting a shipment on hold

You can place a shipment on hold and release it. Use it when a shipment has genuinely stopped — cargo not ready, payment held, documents missing — and it tells everyone else why.

You cannot cancel a shipment, complete it or close it. Those are your operations manager's. A shipment that should be cancelled goes to them with a reason, and the reason is the useful part.

Exceptions

When something goes wrong, raise an exception on the shipment: what it is, how severe, who owns it, when it is due, and the cost impact if there is one.

Raise it even if you are about to fix it. An exception that existed for two hours and was resolved is data about how often that happens; an exception that was fixed and never recorded is a pattern nobody can see. The number of times a lane goes wrong is what renegotiates the contract.

The exceptions screen lists everything open across live shipments, oldest first. Anything with nobody's name on it is flagged as unassigned.

Free time

Containers past their free days accrue **demurrage**, **detention** or **storage** against the carrier's terms.

The clocks run themselves and write their own charge lines. You do not have to calculate anything and you must not enter these charges by hand — you will duplicate them.

What you *do* have to do is enter the dates the clocks depend on: discharged, gated out, empty returned. A missing "empty returned" date is a detention clock that never stops, which produces a wrong charge and a customer argument you will lose.

The shipment shows free days, chargeable days, per-diem rate, and what has accrued so far. So does the dashboard, in total, at the top.

Customs

You can file and update the customs stage — record the declaration type and number, move it through its statuses, record the duty.

You cannot record the duty **payment**; that is Finance's, and the separation is deliberate.

If you are not the person who does clearance, that is your customs broker's chapter and you can leave it to them. See `05-customs-broker.md`.

Documents

Every file belongs to a shipment and has a **type** — bill of lading, invoice, packing list, certificate of origin, delivery order.

Released or draft. Released documents are visible to the customer, in the portal and on the tracking page. Drafts are not. Release is a decision you make per document, so nothing reaches a customer because somebody forgot the default.

Uploading a new version supersedes the old one. Both stay visible. Never upload a corrected document under a new name to work around the version — a shipment with two bills of lading and no relationship between them is exactly the confusion the versioning exists to prevent.

Customers

You can create and edit customers, and their contacts. Two habits are worth having from day one:

Both names. English and Arabic. The Arabic name is what appears on the Arabic quotation and the Arabic portal, and an entity with only an English name produces a document that reads half-translated to your customer.

A real contact. Name, email, phone. This is what the portal invitation and every notification uses.

Bulk import

If you have arrived with a spreadsheet of customers, contacts, agents, ports or rates, use **Network → Bulk import** rather than typing them in. It checks every row before writing anything and imports nothing at all if any row fails.

Full instructions are in the administrator chapter, §Bulk import, and the same rules apply to you.

What you cannot do, and who to ask

YOU WANT TO	ASK
Cancel or close a shipment	Operations Manager
Mark an enquiry won or lost	Operations Manager or Sales
Accept or reject a quotation	Operations Manager or Sales
Add or change a rate card	Operations Manager
Add an agent, haulier or carrier	Operations Manager
Add a port or place	Operations Manager
Anything on an invoice or a receipt	Finance

YOU WANT TO	ASK
Record duty paid	Finance
See the audit log	Administrator
Get access to another branch	Administrator

Five habits that make the difference

1. **Enter the actual date on the day it happens.** Everything downstream — ETA, exceptions, free time, the customer's tracking page — is only as true as the last date somebody entered.
2. **Put the container and bill numbers in as soon as you have them.** They are how your customer finds their own shipment without ringing you.
3. **Raise the exception even when you are fixing it.**
4. **Never fix a wrong price on the quotation.** Fix the rate card.
5. **Never leave an enquiry unassigned overnight.** The clock is running against your branch either way.

Operations Manager

You hold everything a coordinator holds, plus the reversals, the rate cards and the reference data. This chapter covers the difference.

> Read `00-orientation.md` and then `01-coordinator.md` — everything in the coordinator's chapter is yours too, and it is not repeated here.

What is yours alone

	WHY IT SITS WITH YOU AND NOT BELOW YOU
Cancel, complete and close shipments	A coordinator moves work forward. Reversing it is an escalation, and it should cost a conversation.
Close enquiries won or lost	Win rate is a number that gets managed if the people measured on it can set it.
Accept and reject quotations	The commercial decision, not the administrative one.
Write rate cards	The pricing of every future quotation comes from here.
Add agents, hauliers and carriers	Your partner network is a register, not a free-text field.
Add ports, places and reference data	Deliberately operational, not administrative — see below.
Read reports	The dashboards and every export.

You cannot touch invoices. Approving, issuing, voiding or crediting an invoice is Finance's alone, and an operations manager who could issue invoices is the segregation-of-duties failure an auditor asks about first. This is not an oversight and it is not configurable in the shipped role matrix.

Reading the dashboard properly

The dashboard is built to be read in one pass, top to bottom, and the order is the argument.

The line at the top tells you how many things need you today. When it says nothing does, believe it.

The four numbers that mean something is wrong now

	WHAT IT IS ACTUALLY TELLING YOU
SLA breached	Enquiries you promised to answer and have not. Not a backlog — a broken promise, and it is countable.
Due today	The ones about to join them. This is where a morning is well spent.
Demurrage accruing	Containers past their free days. This number is money leaving, per day, right now.
Exceptions	Everything wrong on live shipments, oldest first.

Oldest first is the whole point. The newest exception has somebody looking at it. The one at the top of that list has been open longest, which usually means it belongs to nobody. Work down from the top, not up from the bottom.

The four numbers that tell you how the business is running

	HOW TO READ IT
Win rate	Quotes won against quotes sent this month. Falling win rate with stable volume is a pricing problem; falling volume with stable win rate is a demand problem. They need different responses.
Average margin	What you keep on a typical quotation before overheads. Watch it against win rate — a rising win rate and a falling margin means somebody is buying work.
Median response	Enquiry to quotation. The number your customers actually experience. Averages hide the bad days; this is the median for that reason.
Enquiries received	Fourteen days, with the previous week for comparison.

The rest

Shipments by stage and by mode — what is moving and how. **Busiest lanes** — by shipment count, which is where rate-card attention pays for itself. **Where the cargo is** — every live shipment drawn as a line; thicker means more of them.

Arriving this week is the one to check on a Sunday morning. Everything on it needs documents ready and clearance arranged before it lands, and the cost of finding out late is demurrage.

Rate cards

Network → Rate cards. This screen is the most valuable one you own, and the subtitle states the case: *a lane with no live buying rate is a lane you are quoting blind.*

The four numbers at the top

	WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT
Live rate cards	Valid today.
Lanes with a buying rate	Distinct lanes you can price from a contract rather than from memory.
Lanes priced blind	**Start here.** You are shipping on these with no buying rate on file. Each one is a margin you are guessing.
Expiring within 30 days	Renew before the next quotation needs them, not after a customer notices.

Buy and sell

Cards come in two directions. A **buy** card is what an agent or carrier charges you and belongs to that partner. A **sell** card is what you publish, either to everyone or to a named customer.

What each lane earns pairs them by lane and shows the thinnest margins first. Those are the lanes to renegotiate — and it is a better list than the one you would write from memory, because it is ordered by fact.

Validity, and the thing it prevents

Every card has validity dates, and the system makes **two overlapping cards on the same lane impossible** — not discouraged, impossible. If an import or an entry is rejected for overlapping an existing card, that is the protection working. Correct the dates on one of the two; do not work around it by creating the card under a slightly different lane.

This is the rule that stops two people quoting the same lane at two different prices in the same week.

Loading a card

Small changes by hand. A carrier contract arriving as a spreadsheet goes through **Network → Bulk import** — see `06-administrator.md`. It checks every line before writing anything, and if a single line fails, nothing is written.

Reference data — and why it is yours

Ports, places, commodities, exception codes, document types, charge types, milestone templates, working calendars.

This sits with operations rather than administration on purpose. A shipment routed through a depot nobody has recorded cannot be booked until somebody records it. If that waits for an administrator, what actually happens is that somebody types the depot into a notes field — and the system grows a free-text "other" that swallows the data it was built to structure.

So you can add a port on the morning a new lane opens. The corresponding responsibility: **add it properly, once.** Two entries for the same port is worse than none, because every report silently splits between them.

Milestone templates

The stages applied to a shipment when it is booked, per mode and direction.

Name them the way your operations people say them out loud, not the way a textbook does. If your team says "gate in", the milestone should say "gate in". People do not tick a checklist written in somebody else's vocabulary, and a milestone that is not ticked is a tracking page that lies to your customer.

Working calendars

Sunday to Thursday, plus your public holidays, per branch. Every SLA clock and every ageing rule counts against this. **Load next year's holidays before January**, or every deadline over the break will be wrong in the same direction.

Partners and agents

Agents, hauliers, carriers — with their compliance documents and expiry dates.

Keep the expiry dates real. An agent whose trade licence expired four months ago is a compliance problem that surfaces during an audit rather than during the job, and the register is only worth having if the dates in it are true.

The reversals

Cancelling a shipment

Available from draft, booked, in transit, on hold. It does not delete anything — the shipment stays, marked cancelled, with everything that happened to it intact.

Give the reason in the record, not in a WhatsApp message. In six months the question will be why, and the record is the only place that will still know.

Completing and closing

Complete means operationally finished — delivered, nothing outstanding. **Close** means financially finished, and it is the last step. Closing a job whose costs have not all landed is how a lane's margin ends up looking better than it was; the accrued free-time charges in particular arrive after delivery.

Check the job's costs before you close it, not after.

Releasing a hold

A held shipment returns to whichever stage it was in. Record why it was released in the exception that presumably caused it — a hold with no exception behind it is a decision nobody can reconstruct.

What to look at, and when

WHEN	WHAT	WHY
Every morning	Dashboard, top to bottom	Breached SLAs and the oldest exception
Every morning	Arriving this week	Documents and clearance, before it lands
Twice a week	Exceptions, oldest first	The top of that list is what nobody owns
Weekly	Demurrage accruing	Money leaving per day
Weekly	Rate cards — expiring within 30 days	Renew before a quotation needs it
Monthly	What each lane earns, thinnest first	The renegotiation list
Monthly	Win rate and average margin together	One without the other misleads
Quarterly	Lanes priced blind	Contracts to go and get
Before January	Working calendars	Next year's holidays

Things worth refusing

A coordinator asking you to fix a price on a quotation. Fix the rate card. Fixing the quotation fixes one job and hides a fault that will produce ten more.

A request for a free-text field. Every one of them is a report that cannot be run. If the data has categories, it belongs in reference data where it can be counted.

Closing a job to tidy the board. The board is meant to show what is outstanding. A tidy board with open costs behind it is a management report that is wrong.

Backfilled milestone dates. A week of dates entered on Thursday is a shipment that looks perfect and tells you nothing — and a customer who watched the tracking page say nothing for four days.

Sales

You own the enquiry from the moment it arrives until it is won or lost.

> Read `00-orientation.md` first.

What you hold

Everything from enquiry to award, and nothing operational.

YOU CAN	YOU CANNOT
Create, assign and price enquiries	Book or update a shipment
Send and revise quotations	Touch customs, documents or free time
Accept and reject quotations	Add or change a rate card
Close an enquiry won, lost or cancelled	Add an agent, haulier or carrier
Create and edit customers and contacts	Anything on an invoice or receipt
Read shipments — see what you sold, running	
Read the dashboards and export them	

The two in bold are yours and not the coordinator's. You decide what was won and what was lost, because that is the number you are measured on and it is not a number an administrator should be setting for you.

The queue

Commercial → Enquiries. Every enquiry in every branch you work in, from the web form, from email, from the phone.

Two things matter about an enquiry beyond its content:

It has an owner. An enquiry with no owner has nobody's name against the clock. The queue flags unassigned ones. Assign them — to yourself if nobody else — before you do anything else in the morning.

It has a deadline, counted in working hours on your branch's calendar. The dashboard shows what has breached and what is due today, and the SLA watch list is ordered by whichever breaches soonest.

The clock stops when a quotation is sent. It does not stop because somebody opened the enquiry, and it does not stop because you replied by email outside the system — which is the most common way a good response time is recorded as a breach.

Pricing

Open the enquiry and rate it. The system finds a live rate card for the lane, mode and date, calculates chargeable weight for the mode, and applies the accessorials from the catalogue.

The internal comparison

This is the screen that is worth learning properly. It shows every option with **buy, sell and margin side by side** — before the quotation goes out.

You are seeing the margin at the moment of quoting rather than at month-end. Two consequences worth internalising:

- **A thin margin is a decision, not an accident.** If you send it anyway, you did so knowingly, and that is a defensible answer when somebody asks later.
- **Discounting has a visible floor.** You can see what you are giving away as you give it.

When there is no rate

You will be told there is no live rate card for the lane rather than given a number that looks plausible. That means nobody has a buying rate on file and whatever you quote is from memory.

Tell your operations manager rather than working around it. The rate-card screen has a panel counting exactly these lanes, and yours is a data point that gets a contract negotiated.

The quotation

Sent on your letterhead, in Arabic or English, with your terms and a validity date.

Revising supersedes. The previous version is marked superseded and stays readable — so when a customer says "your first price was lower", the first price is still there, exactly as sent. Revise rather than editing, always.

Validity expires on its own. A quotation past its validity moves to expired without anyone touching it, which is what stops a customer accepting a March price in September.

Closing

You close the enquiry, and how you close it is the data.

CLOSE IT AS	WHEN
Won	The customer accepted. Accept the quotation too — that is what carries the agreed rates onto the job file, so what was sold is what gets costed.
Lost	They went elsewhere, or did not proceed.
Cancelled	The cargo does not exist, it was a duplicate, or it was never real.

Lost and cancelled are not the same thing and the difference is worth protecting. Lost means you competed and did not win — that is a win-rate number and a pricing signal. Cancelled means there was nothing to win. A team that cancels its losses has a win rate that looks excellent and means nothing, and the first person misled by it is you.

Close the lost ones. An enquiry left open because the answer is disappointing sits in the queue, counts against the branch, and pollutes the response-time median. It costs more to leave it than to close it.

Customers

You can create and edit customers and their contacts.

Both names, every time. English and Arabic. The Arabic name is what appears on the Arabic quotation and in the Arabic portal — a customer record with only an English name produces a document that reads half-finished to the person you are trying to impress.

A real contact with a real email. It is what the portal invitation uses, and the portal is the thing that stops them ringing your coordinators.

What to watch on the dashboard

	READ IT AS
Median response	What your customers actually experience, enquiry to quotation. The median rather than the average, because averages hide the bad days.
Win rate	Quotes won against quotes sent this month.
Average margin	What you keep on a typical quotation, before overheads.
Enquiries received	Last fourteen days, against the previous week.
Busiest lanes	Where your volume actually is — often not where you think.

Read win rate and average margin together, always. Rising win rate with falling margin means the team is buying work. Falling win rate with rising margin may be exactly right. Either number alone will mislead you, and the dashboard puts them next to each other for that reason.

Five habits

1. **Nothing stays unassigned overnight.** The clock runs regardless.
2. **Quote in the system, not from your mailbox.** A quotation sent by email outside the system is a breached SLA in the record and an argument you cannot win six months later.
3. **Revise, never edit.** What you sent is evidence.
4. **Close your losses honestly.** Lost is not cancelled.
5. **Report every lane with no rate card.** It is how the contract gets negotiated, and it is your margin next quarter.

Finance

Invoicing, receipts and receivables. Yours alone, and deliberately so.

> Read `00-orientation.md` first.

What you hold, and why nobody else does

YOURS ALONE	ALSO YOURS
Approve an invoice	Record duty paid on a customs declaration
Issue an invoice	Read every shipment
Void an invoice	Read and export the dashboards
Raise a credit note	
Record a receipt	

Only Finance may issue, void or credit. An operations manager who could issue invoices is the classic separation-of-duties failure, and it is the first one an auditor asks about. It is enforced by the system, not by an instruction — which is the answer you can give when asked.

You **cannot** book or update shipments, change rate cards, or send quotations. If an invoice is wrong because the job is wrong, the job gets fixed by operations and the invoice gets credited by you. Neither of you fixes the other's record.

The receivables screen

Finance → Overview. The subtitle is the whole job: *what you are owed, how late it is, and who to ring about it.*

	WHAT IT MEANS
Owed to you	Across every open invoice
Overdue	Past the due date
Received	What has come in
Unallocated receipts	**Money in the bank not yet matched to an invoice**

Unallocated receipts are the one to clear first

The screen warns about them explicitly, and the reason is worth stating: *until a receipt is matched, the customer still shows as owing money they have already paid.*

Every consequence of that is bad. You chase a customer who has paid. Their credit limit blocks a booking they are entitled to. Your ageing report overstates the debt and your management makes decisions on it.

Clear them daily. It is ten minutes and it is the highest-value ten minutes in this chapter.

Ageing

Everything unpaid, grouped by how late it is: not due yet, 1–30, 31–60, 61–90, over 90. The screen offers a piece of judgement with it — *anything beyond 60 days is usually a phone call, not a reminder* — and it is right.

Who owes the most

Largest balance first, not oldest. **Chase the biggest exposure before the oldest debt.** A four-month-old invoice for a small amount is an irritation; a six-week-old invoice for a large one is a risk.

Use the ageing view to decide *how* to chase and this view to decide *whom*.

Invoicing

The states, and what each one commits

STATE	WHAT IT MEANS	REVERSIBLE?
Draft	Being built. No number yet. Charges can be added and changed.	Yes
Approved	Reviewed and ready. Still no number, still editable.	Yes — back to draft
Issued	**It takes the next number in the branch's series.**	**No**
Part paid / **Paid**	Receipts matched against it	—
Void	Cancelled. The number stays used.	No
Credited	A credit note replaces it	No

Issuing cannot be undone. The system says so before you do it. An issued invoice can only be corrected by a credit note — and that is the point, because an invoice that can be silently edited after the customer has it is not a document either of you can rely on.

Voiding keeps the number. The series has no gap. An invoice series with a missing number is a question at every audit, and the answer *"we deleted it"* is never a good one.

Building it

Add charges while it is a draft. Each line carries:

- **Description** — what the customer will actually read
- **Charge type** — groups the line on the printed invoice
- **Quantity, unit price**
- **Taxable** — tax is added at this invoice's rate where the line is taxable

Totals recalculate from the lines. There is no total you type over.

Tax treatment

Set per invoice: **standard rate**, **zero rated**, **exempt**, **out of scope**, **reverse charge**.

This is not decoration — it is what makes an invoice raised by your UAE entity and one raised by your Kuwait entity both correct at the same time. Set it from the entity and the transaction, not from habit.

Document language

Each invoice carries its own language, English or Arabic. Set it to what the customer wants to receive, not to what you are reading the screen in.

Currency

Every charge line stores **its own exchange rate and the moment it was taken**. A job quoted in dollars and invoiced in dinars reconciles months later because the rate is recorded rather than recalculated.

Amounts round per currency at the line. KWD carries three decimal places and the system knows it. You do not need to correct dinar amounts for rounding, and you should not try.

Receipts

Finance → Payments. What came in, and how much of each has been matched.

Record: the date received, the customer, their reference, the method — bank transfer, cheque, cash, card or offset — and the amount.

Then allocate it. A receipt can be matched across several invoices, and part of a receipt can sit unallocated if the customer has overpaid or paid on account. The register shows what is matched and what is not, and the overview screen counts the unmatched ones at the top.

Recorded by is captured automatically. So is the time. Neither can be changed afterwards.

Duty

You can record duty paid on a customs declaration. So can the customs broker and the operations manager; a coordinator cannot.

The declaration shows the duty assessed. Recording payment moves the declaration forward toward release, and it is usually what somebody is waiting on — a container sitting for a payment nobody recorded is demurrage accruing on your own delay.

Charges that appear without anyone entering them

Free-time clocks write their own charge lines. Demurrage, detention and storage accrue against the carrier's free days and post automatically, against the right counterparty at the right per-diem rate.

Two consequences for you:

1. **Do not enter these by hand.** You will duplicate them.
2. **They arrive after delivery.** A job closed the day it was delivered may close before its last accrued charge lands. This is why the operations manager is told to check job costs before closing, and it is worth being the person who reminds them.

Export

Financial data exports whole, in a form your accountant can use.

There is no direct connector to an accounting package in this release. Export and import is the path today. If your accountant needs a specific layout, say so — the export is configurable and it is a smaller job than it sounds.

Your week

WHEN	WHAT
Daily	Unallocated receipts. Clear every one.
Daily	New receipts recorded and matched
Weekly	Overdue — the 61–90 and 90+ buckets, by phone
Weekly	Who owes the most — largest exposure first
On completion	Invoice the jobs operations has completed
Before closing a job	Check the free-time charges have landed
Monthly	Export for the accountant; reconcile the receipt account
Monthly	Check the invoice number series has no gaps — voids should keep theirs

---

Four things not to do

Do not edit an issued invoice by any route. There is no route, and looking for one means the credit note is the answer.

Do not delete a receipt to correct it. Nothing is deleted here. Correct the allocation.

Do not leave money unallocated over a weekend. Everything downstream of it is wrong until you do, including how your colleagues treat that customer.

Do not close the month with unmatched receipts on the register. The ageing report is wrong by exactly that amount, and somebody will act on it.

Customs Broker

A narrow role, on purpose. Declarations, and the shipment fields clearance depends on.

> Read `00-orientation.md` first.

What you hold

YOU CAN	YOU CANNOT
File and update a customs declaration	Create or book a shipment
Record duty paid	Cancel, complete or close one
Update shipments — dates, references, containers	Price an enquiry or send a quotation
Read every shipment in your branches	Add a rate card, agent or port
	Touch an invoice or a receipt

The role is deliberately narrow. You need the declaration and the shipment fields clearance depends on, and nothing else — which also means nothing else can go wrong under your account.

The customs screen

Operations → Customs. Declarations in clearance, **ordered by the window that closes first**.

That ordering is the feature. It is not newest-first and it is not by shipment reference: it is by which clearance deadline expires soonest, so the top of the list is where the next problem is.

Each row shows the shipment, the customer, the declaration number, when it was filed, when clearance is due, the broker, and the duty.

The counters at the top: **in clearance**, **held**, **released**, **inspection required**. Held and inspection are the two that mean somebody must do something today.

The declaration, stage by stage

STAGE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT MOVES IT ON
Not started	Nothing filed	Documents arrive
Waiting for documents	The file is short something	The missing document
Declaration filed	Lodged with the authority	Assessment, or an inspection order
Assessed	Duty determined	Payment — recorded by you, Finance or the operations manager
Duty paid	Settled	Release, or an inspection

STAGE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT MOVES IT ON
Inspection	Physical examination ordered	Release, or a hold
Held	Held by the authority	Re-inspection, or release
Released	Cleared to move	—

A declaration can be held from waiting-for-documents as well. A file short of a certificate long enough becomes a hold, and it looks exactly like a hold caused by the authority. The way to prevent it is to record the missing document as an exception on the shipment the day you notice it, not the day it becomes a hold.

Record the declaration number as soon as you have it. It is what everyone else in the office uses to ask the authority anything, and it is what makes the clearance auditable afterwards.

Free time is running while you are working

Every day a container sits in clearance is a day against its free time. Demurrage, detention and storage clocks run against the carrier's free days and **write their own charge lines** when the free days run out.

Nobody has to notice, which cuts both ways: nobody has to notice, and nobody does. The dashboard shows the total accruing across the branch, and the shipment shows free days, chargeable days and the per-diem rate.

The two dates that stop clocks are yours to enter promptly:

DATE	STOPS	IF YOU LEAVE IT LATE
Gated out	Demurrage at the terminal	The charge keeps accruing on paper after the box has left
Empty returned	Detention on the container	A detention clock that never stops — a wrong charge, and an argument with the customer you will lose

Enter them on the day. Not at the end of the week.

Exceptions

When clearance goes wrong — a hold, an inspection, a document that has not come, a discrepancy in the declared value — **raise an exception on the shipment**.

Give it a severity, an owner and a due date, and the cost impact if there is one. It appears on the operations board, oldest first, and it is how the rest of the office finds out without you telling each of them separately.

Raise it even when you expect to resolve it today. How often a lane, an agent or a commodity produces a hold is a pattern worth having, and it only exists if the short-lived ones were recorded too.

What this system does not do

It does not file declarations. You file where you file today — the authority's own system, your broker portal, an agent. This system records the declaration, its number, its status, the duty and the deadline, so that everyone else can see where clearance has got to without ringing you.

For Kuwait specifically, direct filing is **not planned**. Access runs through a long-standing concession that a supplier of this software has no route into, and that is the honest position rather than a roadmap item.

It does not calculate duty. Record what was assessed.

It does not receive carrier or authority status feeds. Every status change is entered by a person — you.

Your day

WHEN	WHAT
First thing	The customs screen. It is already ordered by which deadline closes first.
First thing	Held and inspection counters — these need action today
On the day it happens	Gated out, empty returned
On the day you get it	Declaration number, duty assessed, release
As soon as you notice	An exception for every hold, inspection or missing document
Weekly	Arriving this week, on the dashboard — clearance you can prepare before it lands

Administrator

You own the deployment. This chapter is what only you can do, and the four things that will hurt if you do them carelessly.

> Read `00-orientation.md` first. You hold every permission in the system, including any added by a future release — so every other chapter in this manual also describes something you can do.

Settings

Settings sits apart from the operations navigation and has its own shell. The reason is stated in the product: *nothing here moves a shipment.* These screens configure the operator — who may sign in, what a branch invoices as, what the product is called.

SCREEN	WHAT IT IS FOR
Users & roles	Who can sign in, and what they hold in each branch
Branches	Currency, invoice series, working calendar, per entity
Audit log	Every write, by whom, from where
Vendor access	What your supplier's support can see, and for how long
Brand	Colours, name and mark, and the variable behind each

Reference data deliberately stayed in operations. Ports, charge types, milestone templates and exception codes are daily operational work, and putting them behind an administrative wall is how a system grows a free-text "Other" field that swallows the data it was meant to structure. Your operations manager owns them — see `02-operations-manager.md`.

Users and roles

Adding someone

The product is invitation-only. There is no sign-up form, so there is nothing to bootstrap from and nothing for a stranger to find.

Accounts are created from a shell on the server:

```
pnpm db:create-user --email ops@yourcompany.com --name "Operations" \
                    --role operations_manager
```

That writes, in one transaction, the four rows an account needs: the auth user, the hashed credential, the domain principal, and **a role per branch**. Without the branch role the account signs in and sees nothing — which is the most common way a new user's first day goes wrong.

By default it grants the role in every active branch. To scope it to one:

```
pnpm db:create-user --email kwi@yourcompany.com --name "Kuwait Desk" \
                    --role coordinator --branch KWI
```

The generated password prints once. Give it to the person directly. Do not email it.

Resetting a password

Re-run the same command for an existing email. It resets that password and changes nothing else. **This is the password-reset path** until a mail transport is configured, and it is why there is no "forgot password" link.

Roles are per branch

The same person can be a **coordinator in Kuwait and read-only in Dubai**. That is the intended shape, not a workaround — a person who covers another office during a holiday gets read access there and keeps their own role at home.

Every screen counts and shows only the branches a person holds a role in. There is no "all branches" toggle, and there should not be.

Two-factor

Administrator and Finance must enrol. They are the two roles that can change who has access and can issue money documents. Nobody can opt out, including you.

Choosing a role

Seven roles, described in full in `09-permissions-reference.md`. Three rules of thumb:

Grant the narrowest role that lets someone do their job. The customs broker role exists precisely so that a broker does not need a coordinator's access.

Do not put an operations person in the Finance role because they "help with invoices". The separation between issuing invoices and running operations is the one an auditor asks about first, and it is enforced rather than advised.

Read-only is a real answer. For an owner who wants to look, a new joiner in their first fortnight, or an accountant who needs to see and not touch.

Branches

Each branch carries **its own base currency, its own invoice series and its own working calendar**.

	WHY IT MATTERS
Currency	What the entity invoices in
Invoice series	Numbering is per branch, and gaps are questions at audit. Voided invoices keep their number for exactly this reason.
Working calendar	**Every SLA clock and ageing rule counts against this.** Kuwait, Qatar and the UAE share neither a weekend nor a holiday list.

Load next year's public holidays before January. If you do not, every deadline over the break is wrong, in the same direction, for every branch — and nobody notices until a customer does.

The audit log

Every write, recorded **by the database itself** rather than by the application — so a change that goes around the application is still recorded. When, what operation, which table, who, which branch, which record, from which address.

Nobody can edit or delete an entry. Update and delete are revoked from every role in the system, including yours and including your supplier's. This is not a policy; it is a permission that does not exist.

Read it when a figure is disputed or a change needs attributing. That is what it is for, and it is worth telling your team it exists — not as a threat, but because a team that knows changes are attributable argues less about what happened.

Vendor access — the one to understand properly

Support cannot see your data by default. There is no standing access, no support account with a permanent key, and no back door.

When your supplier needs to look at something, **you grant it**, from **Settings → Vendor access**:

FIELD	WHAT TO PUT
Engineer	The named person. Not a team.
Ticket or reason	e.g. `SUP-1042 — invoice total disputed on KWI-2026-01041`. Recorded against every session opened under the grant.
Expires after	A number of hours. Choose the smallest that is plausible.
Access	Read only, or read and write
Branches	Leave blank for the branches you hold. **Choosing fewer is always safer.**

Read-and-write requires typing `GRANT WRITE` to confirm. The friction is deliberate. Most support work is diagnosis and needs read access only — ask what they intend to change before you grant write, and if the answer is "nothing yet", grant read.

While a grant is live, **a banner sits at the top of every page** of your system saying so, for everyone. Nobody is unaware that an outsider is in.

You can **revoke it in one click**, at any time, without explanation.

Every grant and every session opened under it is recorded permanently, and *that record cannot be edited or deleted by anyone, including your supplier*. So the question "what did they look at" always has an answer.

Habits worth keeping:

- Grant hours, not days
- Grant read unless write has been justified in words you understood
- Grant the branch in question, not all of them
- Revoke when the call ends rather than waiting for expiry
- Read the vendor-access screen once a month even when nothing is open

Brand

Settings → Brand shows every colour, name and mark the product resolves at runtime — and the environment variable behind each one.

The whole product is re-skinned by setting variables. No rebuild, no code change:

```
BRAND_NAME_EN="Meridian Logistics" BRAND_MONOGRAM=M \
BRAND_PRIMARY_HUE=155 BRAND_ACCENT_HUE=25 BRAND_RADIUS=4
```

Both themes, every tonal ramp, every semantic colour and the chart series derive from those tokens. The screen renders the resolved values so the claim is inspectable rather than asserted.

Two things deliberately do not follow your brand, and should not be made to:

Status colours. Positive, caution, critical, info and muted are reserved for state. A board where "held" is calm because it matched a corporate palette is worse than useless. If your brand hue lands within about 15° of one of them, it will read as that status — move the brand hue, not the status colour.

Chart series. Four slots, assigned in order and never cycled. All four are validated for lightness, contrast against both surfaces, and separation under the two common forms of colour blindness, in both light and dark themes. Changing one means re-running that validation.

Bulk import

Network → Bulk import. Bringing existing data in from a spreadsheet, checked row by row before anything is written.

What can be imported

	NOTES
Customers	Both names, code, terms
Customer contacts	Attached to customers by code
Agents and hauliers	The partner register
Ports and places	
Rate cards	Buy — an agent tariff, needs the partner — or sell
Open jobs	For a mid-year cutover
Open receivables	For a mid-year cutover

How it works

1. **Choose what to import**, and the branch. Every row is created against that branch.
2. **Download the template** if you want the columns in the right order.
3. **Choose the file.** CSV or tab-separated, saved from Excel. The first row must be the headings.

4. **Check the file.** Columns are matched to your headings automatically; correct anything your agent named differently. Unmatched columns are listed as ignored so nothing is silently dropped.
5. **Read the result.** Rows read, rows accepted, and every problem with its line number. You can download the problem list.
6. **Import**, only if everything passed.

The rule that matters

A file with any errors imports nothing. Not the good rows — nothing.

That is deliberate and it is worth defending when somebody asks for a partial-import option. A half-imported customer list is worse than no import, because nobody can tell which half is in, and the second attempt creates duplicates of the first.

Rate cards will be rejected for overlapping an existing card on the same lane. That is the protection working — two overlapping cards on one lane are unrepresentable in this system, by design. Fix the validity dates on one of them.

Doing a real migration

Order matters, because later files refer to earlier ones:

1. Ports and places
2. Agents and hauliers
3. Customers
4. Customer contacts
5. Rate cards — sell first, then buy per partner
6. Open jobs
7. Open receivables

Import into one branch first and look at the result before running the rest. Ten minutes of checking here saves a day of unpicking, and there is no undo — the correction path is editing records, not re-running the file.

Operating the deployment

If your supplier operates the deployment, this section is theirs. If you operate it yourself, this is the whole of the job.

COMMAND	WHAT IT DOES
`pnpm db:migrate`	Apply schema migrations. Forward-only.
`pnpm db:seed`	Reference rows and the role/permission matrix
`pnpm db:create-user`	Provision an account that can sign in
`pnpm fleet:status`	What schema version each deployment is on, and whether it is reachable
`pnpm fleet:migrate`	Migrate across deployments, sequentially, with a report
`pnpm fleet:backup`	Dump every deployment

COMMAND	WHAT IT DOES
`pnpm fleet:restore-drill`	Dump, restore into a scratch database, verify, drop

`fleet:restore-drill` **is the one to schedule.** A backup nobody has restored is a hypothesis. The drill restores into a scratch database and checks the *content*, not the exit status — including that the security policies survived, because a restore that drops them produces a database that looks perfect and enforces nothing.

Dumps must be taken through the admin connection. The application account cannot read outside its own branches, so a dump taken as the application role is silently partial — the most dangerous artefact in this whole area, because it looks like a backup.

What only you can break

Granting the wrong role. Every other mistake in this manual is recoverable from the audit log. This one is somebody seeing what they should not, and it is not visible until it matters. Grant the narrowest role.

Granting standing vendor write access. Hours, not days. Read, not write, unless justified.

Forgetting the working calendar. Every SLA in the system counts against it. A missing holiday list is every deadline wrong in the same direction, silently.

An unverified backup. Run the restore drill on a schedule. Do not assume the dump is good because the command exited zero.

What is not in this release

A user-invitation screen	Accounts are created from a shell. It is also the password-reset path.
Self-service password reset	Needs a mail transport configured.
Editing the role matrix from the interface	The matrix is seeded and editable without a release, but not from a screen today.
Email and WhatsApp notifications	In delivery. Templates exist; the sending channels are being finished.
Scheduled reports	In delivery. Every screen exports today.

Tracking your shipments

> **To the operator, before you send this:** this chapter is written to be handed to your customers under your own name. It contains no supplier branding and names no software. Replace `[Company]` with your company name, `[track URL]` with your tracking address, `[portal URL]` with your portal address, and `[phone]` / `[email]` with your operations contacts. Then delete this box.
>
> It has an Arabic counterpart. Send the one your customer reads.

There are two ways to see where your cargo is. Neither of them is ringing us, though you are always welcome to.

	FOR	NEEDS AN ACCOUNT
Track a shipment	A quick check on one shipment	No
The portal	Everything we are moving for you, and your documents	Yes

---

Tracking one shipment — no account

Go to **[track URL]**.

You need two things, both of which are on your booking confirmation:

1. **The shipment reference** — for example `KWI-2026-01041`
2. **A container number, booking number or bill of lading number** from that shipment

Two identifiers rather than one, because a shipment reference on its own could be guessed. Requiring something only you and we would know keeps your shipment details yours.

What you will see

Progress	Each step of the journey, and how many are complete
Route	Where it is going from and to
Vessel or flight	What it is travelling on
Estimated arrival	And the actual arrival once it lands
Containers	Numbers and seals
Documents	Those we have released to you

Steps are marked **completed**, **in progress**, **scheduled** or **revised**. *Revised* means a date has changed since the original plan — usually a vessel schedule — and it stays visible rather than quietly replacing what we told you before.

Arabic and English

The language switch is at the top of the page. It changes everything, including the direction the page reads.

On your phone

The page is built for it. Bookmark it. Your reference is on your booking confirmation and does not change for the life of the shipment.

If nothing is found

Check both values against your booking confirmation — the second identifier must belong to that same shipment. If it still does not work, ring us on **[phone]** or email **[email]** and we will look.

The portal — for your account

[portal URL], with the sign-in we have set up for you. Ask us if you do not have one.

What is there

My shipments. Everything we are moving for you right now, with the next step on each, and what is arriving this week.

Each shipment in full. The same detail as the tracking page, without typing a reference each time.

Documents. Everything we have released to you, ready to download — bills of lading, invoices, packing lists, certificates. Newest first.

About documents

You see what we have released, not everything that exists. A document being prepared, or one waiting on a correction, is not shown until it is final. This is so that you never work from a draft.

If you expected a document and it is not there, ring us — it usually means it is still in preparation, and we would rather tell you that than have you download something we are about to change.

A released document that is later corrected keeps both versions. You will see the current one; the earlier one is not deleted, so if we ever need to agree what was issued and when, the answer exists.

Which one to use

Tracking is for the question *"where is it?"* — quick, no account, works on a phone, and you can forward the link to your own customer with the two identifiers.

The portal is for *"what is happening across everything of ours?"* and for getting documents.

Questions we get asked

Can I see shipments that are finished? The portal shows what is active. Ask us for anything completed and we will send it.

Can more than one person in my company have access? Yes. Tell us who, and we will set them up.

Why do I need two identifiers to track? So that nobody who happens to guess a reference number can see your shipment details. It is your protection, not our bureaucracy.

The estimated arrival changed. Vessel and flight schedules move. When ours changes, the page shows it as *revised* rather than pretending the original date never existed. If a change affects you, we will normally have rung you before you see it.

Something looks wrong. Ring **[phone]** or email **[email]** with the shipment reference. The reference is what makes it findable in seconds.

[Company] · [phone] · [email]

Agents and partners

> **Read this before you promise anything to an agent.** The agent portal is a scaffold in this release, not a working portal. This chapter says exactly what exists today, how to work with your agent network in the meantime, and what the portal will be when it ships.

What exists today

The route exists and is correctly scoped. An agent contact who signs in sees only jobs where their own partner record is named on the shipment — and that scoping is enforced by the database, as one arm of the same policy that separates your branches. It is not an application that was bolted on and then filtered.

The screen itself is a placeholder. It says *"Assigned shipments — shipments where you are named as a partner, and open rate requests"* and shows nothing else. RFQ dispatch, agents responding to rate requests, agents posting milestones and documents, and compliance self-service are **in delivery**, not shipped.

So: do not give an agent a login yet. An agent who signs in and finds an empty screen has learned something about you that is hard to unlearn. Wait until it ships.

The reason it was left this way rather than mocked up is worth knowing, because it is the same reason the rest of this manual is blunt about gaps: a portal that requires real agents to log in and respond cannot be demonstrated convincingly with fake data, so it was scoped correctly and left honest rather than filled in.

How to work with agents today

Everything below is live, and it is the part that carries the operational weight.

The partner register

Network → Partners & agents. Agents, hauliers and carriers, with their contacts.

Keep two things true:

Both names. English and Arabic — they appear on documents.

Compliance documents and their expiry dates. Trade licence, insurance, whatever your jurisdiction requires. **An expiry date that is not maintained is worse than no register**, because it produces confidence that is not warranted, and the moment it surfaces is during an audit rather than during a job.

Until the compliance expiry reminders ship, this needs a diary entry: review the register monthly and chase what expires in the next sixty days.

Naming an agent on a shipment

Add the partner to the shipment. That is what makes the job visible to their contacts when the portal ships — and today it is what makes your own operations board show who is handling the other end.

Do it at booking, not at the point something goes wrong. A shipment with no partner named is one where the answer to *"who is our agent at destination?"* lives in somebody's memory.

Agent tariffs

An agent's rates go in as a **buy** rate card belonging to that partner. Load them once and every quotation on those lanes prices from a contract rather than from a search of somebody's mailbox.

A spreadsheet from an agent goes through **Network → Bulk import** — choose *Rate cards*, direction *Buy*, and the partner it belongs to. Every line is checked before anything is written, and if one line fails, nothing is imported.

A card will be rejected for overlapping an existing card on the same lane. That is the protection working: two overlapping cards on one lane cannot exist in this system. Fix the validity dates on one of them.

Rate requests, in the meantime

Send them the way you send them today — email, WhatsApp, the phone. When the answer comes back, put it in as a buy rate card with the validity the agent quoted. That way the next quotation on that lane prices itself, and the request does not have to be repeated in six weeks.

Milestones and documents from the far end

Your coordinator enters them. When an agent emails a milestone date or a document, it gets entered against the shipment the same day — see `01-coordinator.md`.

The same day, not the same week. Your customer's tracking page is only as current as the last date somebody entered, and an agent's update sitting in a mailbox is a customer ringing you to ask a question the system could have answered.

What the portal will be

When it ships, an agent contact will sign in and see:

Assigned shipments	Jobs where their partner is named — already scoped correctly today
Rate requests	RFQs you have sent them, with responses coming back into your comparison
Rate-card upload	Their tariff, loaded by them, checked the same way your imports are
Milestone and document posting	The far end updating the shipment directly
Compliance self-service	Their own licences and expiry dates, maintained by them

The last one is the quiet win: the compliance register stops being something you chase and becomes something they maintain.

Ask your supplier which release, and get the answer in writing. If you are being told "soon", ask again.

What to tell an agent who asks

> "We have a portal coming where you will see your assigned shipments, respond to rate requests and post milestones directly. It is not open yet and we will tell you when it is. Until then, nothing changes at your end — send us what you send us today."

Do not promise a date you were not given in writing.

Who can do what

The permission matrix, exactly as shipped. Written for whoever asks — a new administrator deciding which role to grant, or an auditor asking how separation of duties is enforced.

> This is the seeded matrix. It is editable without a software release, so if your deployment has been changed, this page describes the starting point rather than your current state. Your administrator can confirm.

The seven roles in one line each

ROLE	IN ONE LINE	TWO-FACTOR
Administrator	Everything, including anything a future release adds	**Required**
Finance	Invoicing, receipts, duty payment. Nothing operational.	**Required**
Operations Manager	Everything a coordinator does, plus the reversals, rate cards and reference data	No
Coordinator	Moves shipments forward. Cannot reverse them.	No
Sales	Enquiry to award. Nothing operational, nothing financial.	No
Customs Broker	Declarations, and the shipment fields clearance depends on	No
Read Only	Sees shipments and reports. Changes nothing.	No

Administrator is not a listed set of permissions. It receives every key, including keys added by future releases — so a new capability cannot ship unreachable. That is why it is not a role to hand out freely.

The full matrix

● held · ○ not held

PERMISSION	WHAT IT ALLOWS	ADMIN	FIN	OPS MGR	COORD	SALES	CUSTOMS	READ
`enquiry.assign`	Give an enquiry an owner	●	○	●	●	●	○	○
`enquiry.rate`	Price an enquiry	●	○	●	●	●	○	○
`enquiry.close`	Close won or lost	●	○	●	○	●	○	○
`enquiry.cancel`	Cancel an enquiry	●	○	●	○	●	○	○
`quote.send`	Send a quotation	●	○	●	●	●	○	○
`quote.revise`	Supersede with a new version	●	○	●	●	●	○	○

PERMISSION	WHAT IT ALLOWS	ADMIN	FIN	OPS MGR	COORD	SALES	CUSTOMS	READ
`quote.accept`	Record acceptance	●	○	●	○	●	○	○
`quote.reject`	Record rejection	●	○	●	○	●	○	○
`job.read`	See shipments	●	●	●	●	●	●	●
`job.book`	Move a shipment out of draft	●	○	●	●	○	○	○
`job.update`	Milestones, dates, references	●	○	●	●	○	●	○
`job.hold`	Place on hold and release	●	○	●	●	○	○	○
`job.complete`	Mark operationally finished	●	○	●	○	○	○	○
`job.close`	Close financially	●	○	●	○	○	○	○
`job.cancel`	Cancel a shipment	●	○	●	○	○	○	○
`customs.file`	Record a declaration	●	○	●	●	○	●	○
`customs.update`	Move it through its stages	●	○	●	●	○	●	○
`customs.pay`	Record duty paid	●	●	●	○	○	●	○
`invoice.approve`	Mark reviewed	●	●	○	○	○	○	○
`invoice.issue`	**Allocate the number. Irreversible.**	●	●	○	○	○	○	○
`invoice.void`	Cancel; the number stays used	●	●	○	○	○	○	○
`invoice.credit`	Raise a credit note	●	●	○	○	○	○	○
`payment.record`	Record and allocate a receipt	●	●	○	○	○	○	○
`finance.export`	Export financial data	●	●	○	○	○	○	○
`rate.card.write`	Create or change a rate card	●	○	●	○	○	○	○
`customer.write`	Create or edit customers	●	○	●	●	●	○	○
`partner.write`	Agents, hauliers, carriers	●	○	●	○	○	○	○
`report.read`	Dashboards and exports	●	●	●	○	●	○	●

PERMISSION	WHAT IT ALLOWS	ADMIN	FIN	OPS MGR	COORD	SALES	CUSTOMS	READ
`admin.reference.write`	Ports, charge types, milestones, calendars	●	○	●	○	○	○	○
`admin.users.write`	Users, roles, **and vendor access**	●	○	○	○	○	○	○
`admin.branches.write`	Branch configuration	●	○	○	○	○	○	○
`admin.audit.read`	The audit log	●	○	○	○	○	○	○
`admin.brand.read`	Branding tokens	●	○	○	○	○	○	○
`admin.api_keys.write`	API keys for the read API and webhooks	●	○	○	○	○	○	○

The four separations that are deliberate

These are the ones to be able to explain, because they are the ones that get asked about.

Finance alone may issue, void or credit an invoice

No operational role holds `invoice.issue`. An operations manager who could issue invoices is the classic segregation-of-duties failure, and it is the first thing an auditor tests.

The reverse holds too: **Finance cannot book, update or close a shipment.** If an invoice is wrong because the job is wrong, operations fixes the job and finance credits the invoice. Neither corrects the other's record.

A coordinator moves work forward; only a manager reverses it

`job.cancel`, `job.close` and `job.complete` sit with the operations manager. `enquiry.close` — deciding won or lost — sits with the manager and with sales.

Reversal is an escalation. It should cost a conversation, and the conversation is where the reason gets recorded.

Reference data is operational, not administrative

`admin.reference.write` is held by the operations manager, despite the `admin.` prefix. Adding a port when a new lane opens is daily work — and if it waits for an administrator, what actually happens is that somebody types the port into a notes field, and the system grows a free-text "Other" that swallows the data it was built to structure.

Vendor access is gated on `admin.users.write`

Granting an outsider access to the deployment is the same authority as granting a colleague access to a branch. Inventing a separate key would let someone hold one without the other, which is a distinction with no meaning.

Two things this matrix is not

It is not the security boundary. It decides what the interface *offers*. The real boundary is in the database: branch separation, immutability and audit are enforced by around 75 policies across 57 tables, plus the state machines that reject an invalid transition regardless of who asked.

The asymmetry is deliberate. A permission check that is forgotten hides a button. A database policy that is forgotten leaks a branch. That is why the expensive guarantees live below the application.

It is not per-record. Permissions are per role; visibility is per branch. Holding `job.update` does not let you update every shipment — only those in branches where you hold a role. A request for a shipment in another branch returns **not found**, because the row is not visible to the query at all.

Roles are granted per branch

The same person can be a coordinator in Kuwait and read-only in Dubai. Grants are per branch, and there is no all-branches switch.

Nobody can widen their own access. Only an administrator can grant a role in another branch, and every grant is in the audit log.

Questions an auditor asks, and the answers

QUESTION	ANSWER
Can an operations manager issue an invoice?	No. `invoice.issue` is held by Finance and Administrator only.
Can an administrator alter the audit log?	No. Update and delete on it are revoked from every role in the database. The permission does not exist.
Can a user see another branch's data?	No. Enforced by database policy, not by the interface. The row is not visible to the query.
Can a user grant themselves access?	No. Only `admin.users.write` can, and every grant is recorded.
Can the supplier see our data?	Not by default and not without a grant from your administrator — scoped to branches, read or write, time-limited, against a ticket, revocable, and permanently recorded.
Is anything ever deleted?	No. Records are superseded, closed, cancelled or deactivated. Delete is revoked from the application's own account on every table.
Who can change the permission matrix itself?	An administrator, through the seed. It is editable without a software release, and the change is audited.